

AT HOME Raghubir Yadav with his onscreen family in *Om Ka Hari*

Raghubir Yadav gives his characters the texture of lives already lived. In his latest film, *Om Ka Hari*, he plays a stubborn father confronting mortality and an estranged son, territory familiar to an actor who has spent a lifetime observing people. Observation is central to his portrayal of a father in the film, caught between love, authority and the fear of losing his son. His character knows how to provide, protect and insist on what he believes is right; what dodges him is the more difficult language of intimacy. Indian fathers are often raised to measure love through responsibility. But responsibility is not always understood. Yadav's performance finds the ache in that distance; the tenderness of a father who loves deeply, yet struggles to understand the deep emotions of the child standing before him.

"I have seen a lot in life," he says. Theatre kept him grounded, as did the places he inhabited, like Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan, from villages and small towns to cities. Observation, for him, became less a technique than a habit of living. "I love playing characters that are real," says Yadav. His characters feel instantly relatable because Yadav doesn't play ordinary lives; he inhabits them.

The actor has never seemed particularly interested in chasing success. "To be a star was never my intention. All I wanted was to be a good actor and to show my craft," he says. There is something almost unfashionable about that distinction today. Cinema is increasingly attuned to youth, appearance and the velocity of visibility; Yadav has built his career by moving at another rhythm. He is drawn to characters with histories, peculiarities and the faint marks of having lived. "I am extremely choosy about my work," he says. "I feel if you run too fast in life and keep chasing, you really don't achieve anything in life. I love the tortoise pace."

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A role, for Yadav, is not simply something to perform but a life to enter, however briefly. "Through my performances in cinema, I want to live each and every life that I play," he says. "I want to understand its layers and nuances." The size of the part, therefore, matters less than what it contains. Yadav's six years in theatre taught him that an actor must not merely study a character but disappear into it. "They don't swim; they drown themselves," he says of the artists he watched. He reads a character "again and again to understand it better", until, somewhere in that repetition, "I become that character".

Yadav credits Barry John and Ebrahim Alkazi with teaching him "how to just do my work and find happiness through my craft". The entertainment industry may have its distractions, but he has learned to keep his distance. "There will be many people to make the creative *mahaul* (environment) bad," he says. "But you don't need to be a part of that group." His instinct has always been to wait.